

Main

Report Name (Org_Country_Year_Report Type)

F4E_Kenya_2024-25_3-month Report

Fellowship Organization

Food for Education Foundation (F4E)

Fellowship City

Nairobi

Fellowship Country

Kenya

Fellowship Start Date

08/05/2024

Anticipated Fellowship End Date

08/05/2025

What is your fellowship title/role?

Fundraising Associate/Fellow

What are your primary responsibilities?

- writing and managing quarter, annual, and standard reports to donors
- writing and managing concept notes and proposals to donors
- scoping and supporting/executing different philanthropic and multi/bilateral funding opportunities
- executing and distributing communication materials for various donors (writing blogs, submitting pictures, conducting interviews, directing videos to film)
- collaborating to write quarter and annual reports to internal and external stakeholders on F4E's recent developments
- leading internal team, cross-departmental, and external meetings

I receive adequate direction and support to perform my fellowship responsibilities.

Strongly Agree

Did you receive any sort of orientation, handover or onboarding when you started your fellowship?

Yes

Please describe your orientation/onboarding and note who handled it.

My orientation was a week long and was led by an HR member. I had an "office buddy" who was the previous PiAf fellow, and throughout the week with a group of others who joined at the same time, I attended meetings with each department to learn more about their functions.

If you did not receive any kind of orientation, what information or guidance were you provided at the start of your fellowship?**Describe a representative day at work.**

My days look different pending on projects, partner visits, donor visits, etc. Generally after I arrive, I check my email, Slack, and Calendar to know if I need to edit my personal task list for the day. Most days I'm working on different reports that are due or various communication pieces. Then I might have 1-2 meetings for the day.

On average, how many hours per week do you work?

40

How would you describe your effectiveness in your fellowship post so far?

Very Effective

Please briefly describe 1-2 specific projects that you have undertaken or accomplishments you have made so far.

From the beginning (to now the tail end) spearheading the courting procedure with a new donor. This included writing a concept note, proposals, filling out submissions, answering additional due diligence questions.

Constructed multiple slide decks for a big wave of partner meetings we had, and had the chance to give the presentation for a partner we've been exploring a project with as part of our brief.

What is your organization's work culture like?**What is your office environment like? Please comment on the size and structure of the office(s) where you do most of your work.**

It's in a big office building in the hub of Nairobi, F4E has 3 separate rooms and shares the floor with 3 other companies. It is an open coworking space-esque layout with a very modern and green design. I work in the office 3 times a week, remotely 2 days (I began working remotely after 3 mo). I sit next to my team plus people from HR, Comms, and Tech.

To whom do you report?

I report to the Head of Fundraising who was also a Princeton in Africa Fellow. I additionally report to Senior Manager who has been added as my supervisor. I submit the first drafts of reports to the Senior Manager and then send the final review to the Head of Fundraising before anything goes out to donors/stakeholders.

Have you had an initial check-in with your supervisor to set up a work plan and to set goals for your work during your fellowship year?

Yes

Was this meeting helpful in understanding your role and setting goals for your fellowship year?

yes

Please explain why you have not met with your supervisor and if you have plans to do so going forward.

Please briefly indicate 3-5 professional goals you have for the rest of your fellowship year. Your professional goals should align with your work plan.

1. Personally identify a funding opportunity and execute it to the finish through the grant life cycle
2. Increase opportunities for staff to engage with sponsoring children, overall improving employee buy-in
3. Strategize and execute a way for expansion and scale strategy to be disseminated to the staff at the organization

How often do you check in with your supervisor?

Weekly

Have you had an opportunity to travel for work so far?

Yes

Describe this travel opportunity. Include location(s) and a brief description of the purpose of the trip(s).

Yes: Visiting schools and kitchens in Murang'a, Juja, Kisumu, and Ruiru (outskirts of Nairobi). There are loose plans to visit Mombasa and other kitchens and schools later on in the year.

I feel adequately prepared for my position's professional responsibilities.

Strongly Agree

Please briefly explain your response.

Although I have never written grants before, my compelling writing and strong research and collaboration skills lend themselves very well to learning how to best communicate with a donor for proposals and reports.

How did you travel to your host country and site? Please be specific

I purchased my ticket from Washington DC to Nairobi. I flew on Qatar Airways from IAD to DOH, DOH to NBO. It took my visa a long time to arrive (responsibility was on my org to process this) so I had to book a one-way about a week before flying out, flights increased a lot more than their initial allocation in the contract but they covered the one-way flight (USD 1109.50) and visa costs fully.

What kind of visa/ permit do you have or applied for?

F4E will completely guide you on this process. I initially came on a tourist eTa pass but after I signed my contract in the Spring they began the paperwork for the Student/Researcher Pass to obtain my

How did you obtain (or are obtaining) your visa or permit?

eTa online, student/researcher pass filled out application provided by F4E then went to Nyayo House 2x for Alien Card

Did you apply for and receive your visa / permit before heading to your host country or after arriving?

partially (get fingerprints and diploma translation-if necessary) done ahead of time

What costs were associated with obtaining your visa or permit?

eTa: \$35; Diploma Translation (latin to english):\$65; Police Certificate: \$50

Did you pay the visa / permit costs or were they covered by your organization?

Yes, fully

Are you still having challenges obtaining your visa/ permit?

No

If yes, please explain further

g) Do you have any suggestions to help future Fellows navigate the visa / permit application process?

Process everything you can before you leave, ask HR all clarifying questions you need

What vaccinations were you required to obtain prior to your departure? How much did your vaccinations cost? Did you get a yellow fever vaccination?

I only got tetanus I believe, no Yellow Fever.

How was your arrival and first week in your host country? Any improvements that could streamline the assimilation process for future Fellows?

It was fine I arrived on a Thursday and started work the following Monday. I would highly advise giving yourself 4-7 days prior to starting work to get phone/MPESA set up, meet the other fellows in Nairobi, buy groceries/set up living space. It's truly difficult to do anything without setting up MPESA/ESIM, I would highly advise that that be the first thing you do to get around in the city and have a Kenyan phone # for any important forms and documents.

Additionally, depending on what neighborhood you reside in I would advise briefly walking around your neighborhood to get more familiar with your surroundings. I was a bit hesitant to do that out of fear/security but just leave your phone at home and walk around if possible.

Is housing provided by and/or paid for by your organization? Please explain.

No and no support was provided in locating housing.

Do you live in a location that is more urban or rural?

Very Urban

Please describe your living environment

Very urban, right next to a major highway and shopping malls.

How do you typically travel between your home and your work? How much does your daily transportation cost and how long is your commute?

Uber costs about \$7 USD daily, with an average of 15-35 minutes commute time.

If you live in a more rural area, what are the closest urban areas you can travel to for shopping, airport, larger medical centers, etc.?

N/A

How is the weather in your host country? What season are you presently in?

It was a bit chilly in August and September (I would wear a light jacket daily), so pack a light jacket and sweater for that time. Now it is warmer and it's been raining for the past few weeks. Colleagues have said that the weather this year has been unpredictable but so far I haven't experienced any extreme temperatures (don't need a heavy winter jacket, but pack good rain gear- boots and a jacket).

What is the appropriate clothing for work and outside of work at your fellowship post and in your community in general?

Overall, people in the office dress quite casually, and outfits vary widely. There is quite a relaxed culture at HQ but I generally wear business casual-dress shirts and slacks/jeans, long skirts, sweater dresses, etc. I rarely wear a blazer and heels to work, coworkers come in dress shirts/pants, jerseys and jeans, leggings and hoodie, to a full-piece suit, you can truly wear whatever you want. During school and kitchen visits, generally keep business casual outfits but wear boots due to mud/dirt.

Nairobi is generally more conservative than most cities in the US and people opt for more "decent" clothing; I personally avoid yoga pants, sweat pants, leggings, ripped jeans, and revealing tops to better blend in and be respectful. Additionally, most people dress casually here

with less flashy clothes, brands, and jewelry. Clubs and different creative events allow for more freedom in clothing, but most people still keep a more casual style when going out.

How have you been spending your free time?

There is a LOT to do in Nairobi, that's been one of my favorite things about living here. Almost everything you have access to/can think of in the US is here-run clubs, paint and sips, movies, pilates, yoga, etc you might just have to pay a higher rate for more "Western" activities. Most weekends I'm cafe hopping, meeting with people, going to church, going to different events like book talk discussions; comedy nights; and watching socially provocative films, trying new restaurants, farmers markets, etc. Usually, the Nairobi cohort also tries to plan 1 thing a week whether it's going to the events listed above together or movie nights/happy hours. With many fellows in Kenya and many tourist spots throughout the country, I also leave the city to explore and host fellows/visitors when they come to Nairobi.

There is also a very big expat population in Nairobi that I am still trying to navigate interactions with. This is a city where it's easy to get sucked in expat bubbles and is difficult to avoid at times with shared experiences and interests, but I try to be conscious of which spaces I'm spending my time and money in.

Additionally, with the work culture in Nairobi, coworkers keep mostly strict personal and professional boundaries. They are very warm and welcoming but tend to tread more cautiously than the general office culture in the US; it took me about 3 months to slowly start breaking the barrier with coworkers and begin hanging out outside the office. I advise to not have the same expectations as a US office and to try your best to continue being friendly showing interest in their lives and taking it at their pace.

I've been able to successfully navigate my personal/social life both back at home and at my fellowship post.

Strongly Agree

Please briefly explain your response below.

Mostly very positive, although the 8 hr time difference can be challenging with work schedules here in Nairobi and DC, most friends call during their lunch breaks or on the weekends. I additionally very regularly call my family either as I wait for Uber or on weekends. I attempted to plan weekly weekend calls with different groups but that hasn't been successful. I also keep a travel Instagram account to update friends as to what I'm up to. Sometimes it's easy to expect the ones who are at home to be checking in but they also have their own lives, so sending voice memos helps quite a bit. I am also planning to go home for Christmas briefly and am really looking forward to it.

Would you say you live and work in a safe area?

Yes, crime rate is relatively low, I both work and live in Westlands-one of the safest areas in Nairobi.

What precautions do you take to ensure your safety?

Just like any foreign city you have to be extra alert, especially if you present as a foreigner at face value. I share my location with a fellow here and family back home, I try to share an uber with people late at night. I also have significantly limited walking anywhere really, especially anytime after sundown. I also make sure windows are closed and doors are locked in ubers, and I don't ride boda bodas (motorcycles)-despite having ridden them in other countries it's truly driven recklessly in Nairobi.

Additionally, petty crime is really common here. My phone was stolen a few weeks into the fellowship and I now take my replacement phone and leave my new iPhone at home or in hotel rooms anytime I go to bars, clubs, beaches, very touristy spots, or anywhere with a lot of people present.

What has been your experience with crime so far? (Please note that any security or safety concerns or incidents should be reported directly to PiAf staff per PiAf safety and security protocol.)

My phone was stolen at a bar in Nairobi.

Describe the incidence of crime and the general security situation within your city/town. Could you recommend specific areas future Fellows might consider for safe housing? What about areas that should be avoided?

Petty theft and especially phone theft is VERY common in Nairobi, many coworkers here have experienced this in addition to past fellows. I have personally never experienced this despite having quite a good amount of traveling/going out around the world under my belt. I'm grateful that it was not violent at all.

I checked to see if my phone was in my crossbody bag on the dancefloor and saw my bag was open and the phone had been taken. The security/bar was useless and attempted to go to the police to track it through the IMEA# as findmyphone was disabled, but was once again useless and very frustrating.

You truly really need your phone to do anything in Nairobi (Ubers and Mpesa- there are very limited Card and cash options in the city) so really hold on to it and if possible bring a backup burner phone. I bought a cheap replacement one the next day and had my parents activate a new one and send it through someone coming to Nairobi a few weeks later. Seeing their apathy and processes to something as simple as a phone really showed me that the police are not here to truly protect nor do they have the means to, so please seriously take care of yourself.

Common areas safe for foreigners to live are Westlands, Parklands, Lavington, Kileleshwa, and Kilimani. Although these are also the most expensive areas, work to find something within your price range and bargain with landlords on the Facebook pages. I'd advise securing a place with a guard/security 24/7 and living in a gated apt for peace of mind.

For the F4E office, because of its high traffic location, you need to be at a place right by Waiyaki Way (Lavington or Parklands), what's stated on Google Maps (20 min) vs the reality is very different. When speaking with HR, please state that traffic is a concern for you and vet the location during rush hour time. It will seriously kill your time and money, and moving to another location is a hassle (and getting your deposit back in Nairobi can be difficult at times). Ex: even after moving to an apt closer to work that takes 10-15 min in the morning, it will take 30-45+ min if I leave at 5 pm.

Please refer back to the goals you set for yourself before orientation. Are you working towards these goals? Have you met any of them? Changed any of them? Please explain.

Yes, I am definitely working towards these goals. I took up learning Swahili for a bit, I've continued to say yes to new experiences, and have definitely been challenging and expanding my view of International Development, especially by working at a 99% Kenyan office. I think all of these goals are still a work in progress and my perception of whether I've "met" these goals such as finding experiences that'll challenge me will evolve as I stay longer in Nairobi.

Do you have any frustrations with your living arrangements, your work or your life outside of work?

I did initially with my living arrangements, but took steps to resolve the issue.

Has there been anything that you have needed but have not been able to locate or acquire?

Not really, maybe natural hair products from the US. You can easily find things in Nairobi, you'll just have to pay quite a bit for anything imported.

How have you dealt with "culture shock"?

To be honest, I don't think I've experienced too much culture shock here, Nairobi is very similar to any "Western" city. I'd say the closest thing to "culture shock" that I've been experiencing might be the level of efficiency here. Most processes and services are really slow like Ubers, paperwork, nail/hair salon, traffic, asking things from colleagues, restaurant and service wait times, etc.

It took a while to get adjusted to the concept of time here, but it is just different and a bit annoying compared to a faster-paced life in the US.

I just try to remind myself that my perception of time and efficiency is not the only "right" way and allot extra time when I need to do things cause things will always take longer than I anticipate.

What about your experience thus far has been the most...surprising?

Really quickly feeling welcomed onto the team and by the general staff.

What about your experience thus far has been the most...challenging?

Housing Crisis and losing my phone at a bar.

What are the top 3 things you miss the most from your home country or the U.S.?

Freedom to walk and drive around on my own accord, efficiency of everything , and Chick fil A.

What are the top 3 things about life in your host country that beat out life in your home country or the U.S.?

People are kinder and more helpful here, nature and wildlife are unbeatable, and there is so much to do in Nairobi at all times-many scenes to check out

How is your stipend being paid?

Monthly (at the end of every month), in USD to US Account

How are you receiving your stipend funds?

Wire

Did you raise funds to cover part of your fellowship expenses?

No, but relied on familial support and worked a summer job prior to coming to Nairobi.

Please list any additional one-time or infrequent expenses not included in your monthly budget below.

Monthly Budget

Rent	Utilities	Furnishings	Phone	Home Security	Internet
\$427.00	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$4.98	\$0.00	\$0.00
Transportation	Fitness	Entertainment	Groceries	House Cleaning	Eating Out
\$139.99	\$0.00	\$60.00	\$80.00	\$0.00	\$130.00
Medications	Additional Health Insurance	Travel	Laundry	Other	Total Monthly Budget (Minus Entertainment & Travel)
\$0.00	\$0.00	\$100.00	\$0.00	\$20.00	801.97
Specify "Other"					
Hair Care					

Final Thoughts

Please briefly explain your response about Orientation.

I thought it was okay, I appreciate that they had a specific country breakout session for Kenya fellows.

Additionally, I didn't think the virtual format was that productive or conducive to cohort bonding. The greater cohort feels quite disconnected from each other and I'm grateful to be in a country with many fellows, but think that prioritizing and planning an initial in-person meet-up would further enhance the purpose of a cohort.

Is there anything in particular that PiAf could cover at orientation that would have better prepared you for your fellowship post? Please specify.

I know that PiAf has to keep most information at a high-level overview but information on things like locating housing (outside of suggesting to take over old fellows leases) would be very helpful.

Are you receiving sufficient support, materials and information from the Princeton in Africa office? What could we improve?

Yes.

As we plan the upcoming PiAf Retreat, we hope to incorporate some Fellow suggestions into our programming. What are some topics or sessions you would like to see at the Retreat? (We appreciate your feedback however, we may not be able to accommodate all suggestions or requests this year.)

Leveraging fellowship experience for Masters programs.